

Tamil film classics.

"I've had a long journey from the time I first started competing. So when I got selected for these Asian Games, the first conversation I had with my coach Neha was that I had got my second opportunity to compete at an Asian Games eight years after my first. I was just grateful that I was getting the chance to be part of an Indian contingent and represent the country," she said.

Before the competition, Elavenil had spoken to Neha, who has been part of her journey since she first picked up an air rifle 13 years ago.

"Neha just told me that I'd put in all the hard work already. She said, 'You've trained your absolute best. Just trust your technique and be courageous,'" Elavenil recalled.

The first step was simply to qualify for the final. There was no guarantee she would make it.

After the first series of shooters had completed their qualification round, Elavenil knew she would need to be at her best not only to make the individual final but also to keep India's team-medal hopes alive.

At the start of her series, India trailed Japan by 0.7 points and Korea by 2.9 points in the team event. Those were the gaps Elavenil had to close.

She did so without missing a beat, shooting an unruffled 633.5 to qualify for the final and help ensure India finished ahead of both Japan and Korea.

That is why Elavenil's emotions cannot simply be summed up by how she felt after the final.

Amid the equipment, snacks and other odds and ends in her shooting kitbag, Elavenil carries a small scrapbook to every competition. Once she has finished competing, she writes down how she thinks she has done. It is an immediate and honest assessment of her emotions, one she says she uses to get better in the future.

On Sunday morning, after the women's 10m air rifle qualification, Elavenil fished it out and wrote down a single sentence.

"I did my best today."

'I believe she will be a completely changed person' – Narang

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The numbers lined up perfectly, 16 years apart.

Two Indian shooters, both former World No. 1s from Tamil Nadu, won silver medals at the Asian Games in two identical events.

Gagan Narang finished second in both the individual and team 10m air rifle events at Guangzhou 2010. Elavenil Valarivan, his protege, matched the feat at the Aichi Prefectural General Shooting Gallery on September 20.

Narang wasn't about to let the coincidence pass without teasing the 27-year-old markswoman. "Just stop copying me," he chuckled when the two spoke on a video call after the medal ceremony.

Elavenil may have replicated one of the most defining results of Narang's career, but the significance of her silver medals lay elsewhere.

After failing to make it past the qualification rounds in the previous two editions of the Olympics and the 2018 Asian Games, she had finally broken through at a multi-discipline event.

That difference was visible even in defeat. Elavenil, who had looked in control for much of the eight-woman final, remained calm as her sizeable lead shrank before home favourite Hinata Taichi pulled ahead and took gold with 253.0.

For Narang, that equanimity is part of her transformation. "Overall, she is more mature now. And wise. She is in a good space at the moment. A lot of times now, she's proved she has more confidence than earlier. At the end of the day, you can shoot all 10.7s, but if the other shooter is registering only 10.8s, you can't win."

That lesson is rooted in Narang's own career. He remembers entering the London Olympics with a very



specific target. In both his first and second Olympics, Athens 2004 and Beijing 2008, his 40th shot had been an 8.9. It became 'a mental block'.

"So, when I was shooting London (2012), my goal was the 40th shot only. I said, whatever happens, the 40th shot should be good," he recalled. "That whole Olympics I only prepared for my 40th shot. Somewhere, I knew if I went through with the 40th shot, I could do very well." Narang went on to win the bronze medal in that edition.

For Elavenil, Narang believes the Asian Games medal can serve a similar purpose. "The Asian Games medal for Ela (as she is lovingly called in the fraternity) was like that monkey off the back," Narang said. "I believe she will be a completely changed person. Her inner thought process, which is good, gives her confidence."

For now, Narang is careful not to claim ownership of Elavenil's success. His role is deliberately less intrusive. Without dictating Elavenil's every move, he aims to be just another resource in her toolkit. The objective is to make the athlete "intelligent enough to choose the right tool at the right time."

Although it makes him proud, Narang isn't interested in preserving the curious numerical symmetry of their careers. He would rather have Elavenil break it soon.